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Class 6: Aspects of Social Movement Activity

Organisation, strategies and tactics

Dr. Michael C. Zeller

Agenda for the day

- Opening notes
- A conceptual framework of *strategy*
- Open data - ACLED protest repertoires
- Open data - POLDEM protest repertoires
- Poll: strategy formation and effect
- Temporality
- Tactics and effecting change
- Any questions, concerns, feedback for this class?

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Opening notes



Presentation groups

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Presentations line-up

Date	Presenters	Method

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A conceptual framework of *strategy*

- strategy defined
- elements of strategy
- drivers of strategy selection
- example from a non-violent but disruptive group
- example from a violent group



Basic, intuitive definition of *strategy*

strategy refers to the approach of an actor(s) to achieve their (political) objectives—connecting actions to goals (*means* to an *end*)

- extant definitions identify some elements, e.g.,
  - "a combination of a claim (or demand), a tactic, and a site (or venue)" (Meyer 2007, 82)
  - Ganz (2010, 9): targeting, tactics, timing
- many groups use mixed strategies of violence and non-violence

Elements of strategy

- informative element: objective(s) (*why*): what are the actor(s) goals? minimalist vs. maximalist objectives

- target (what/who) - what entity is being acted upon?
  - involves choice to commit resources to specific outcomes

- tactics (how) - types of collective action and their form
  - attempt to deploy *strengths*, exploit target's *weaknesses*

- site/venue (where) - what place or what forum type is action taken?

Elements of strategy

- informative element: objective(s) (*why*): what are the actor(s) goals? minimalist vs. maximalist objectives
- target (what/who) - what entity is being acted upon?
- tactics (how) - types of collective action and their form
- site/venue (where) - what place or what forum type is action taken?
- timing (when) - when are tactics employed against targets

What are the strategic elements of social movements that you know of?

Drivers of strategy selection

- strategy is be a product of (rational) choice

BUT…

- it is also a part collective identity (cf. Polletta and Jasper 2001)
  - strategy also involves *moral and emotional committments*

An example from the news...

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How can we characterise the group's *strategy* here?

An example from ‘the 43 Group’

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An example from 'the 43 Group'

post-war Labour government, witnessing low-level fascist-party organising and agitation…

Beckman (2013):

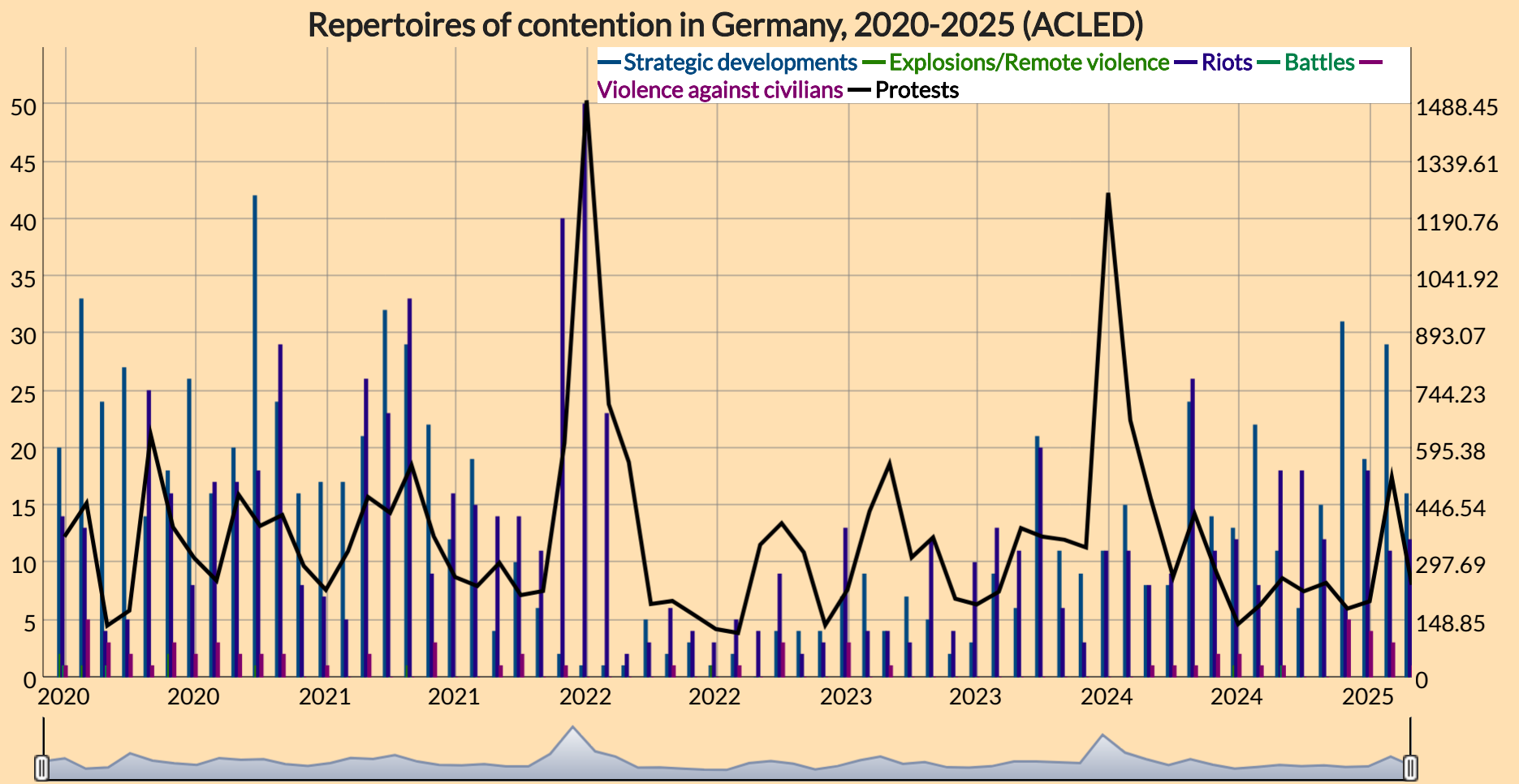
> On Tuesday May 21st [1946], [James] Chuter Ede, the Home Secretary, received a deputation from the JDC [Jewish Defence Committee, part of the Board of Deputies of British Jews] led by the Chairman, Gordon Liverman … They listened to the deputation and said they would consider all the points raised, but nothing tangible happened.

documentary about 43 Group: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oBusQBSCAHY

Open data - ACLED protest repertoires

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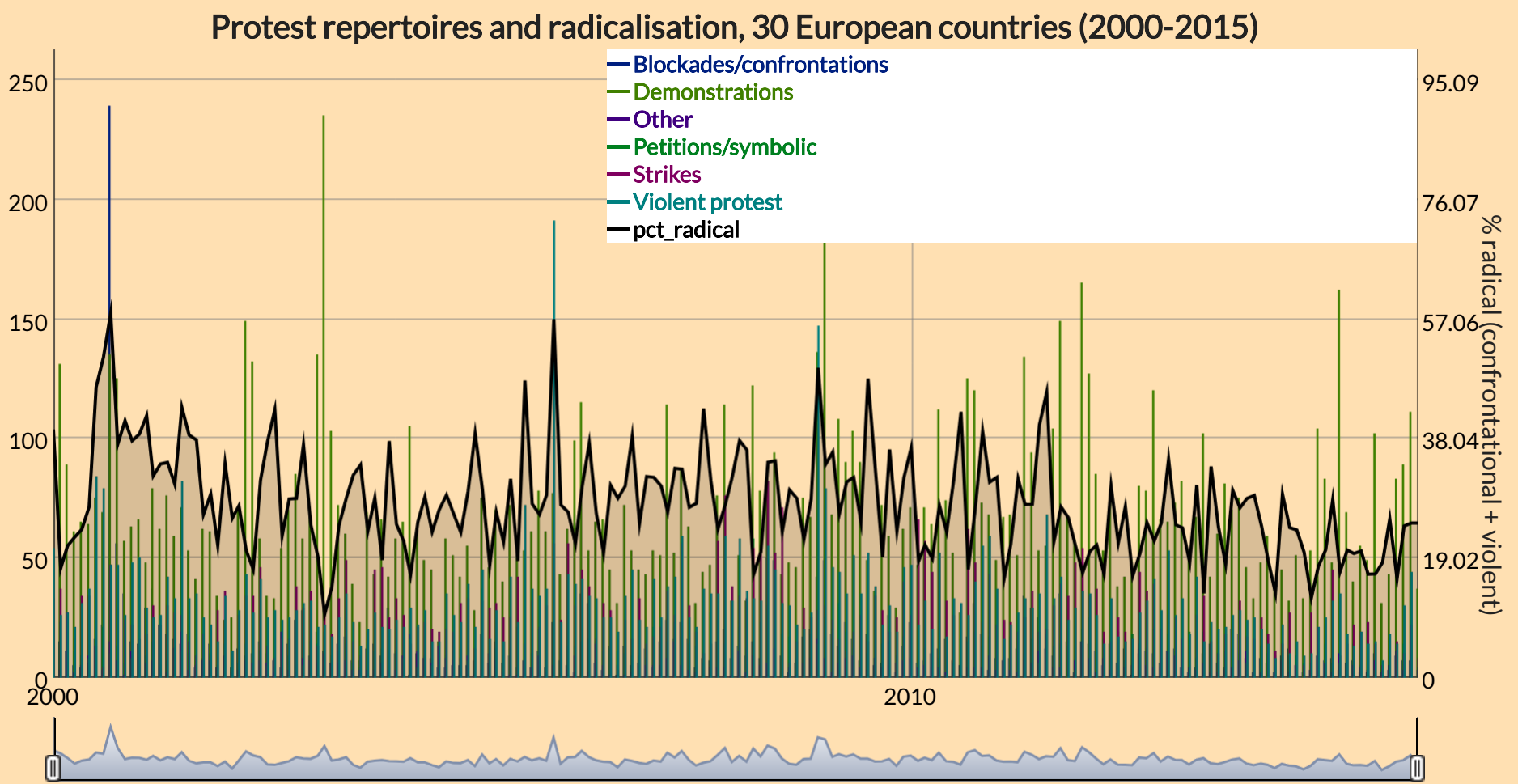
Visualisation | Explanatory note | Data table



Open data - POLDEM protest repertoires

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Visualisation | Explanatory note | Data table



Poll: strategy formation and effec

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Take the survey at
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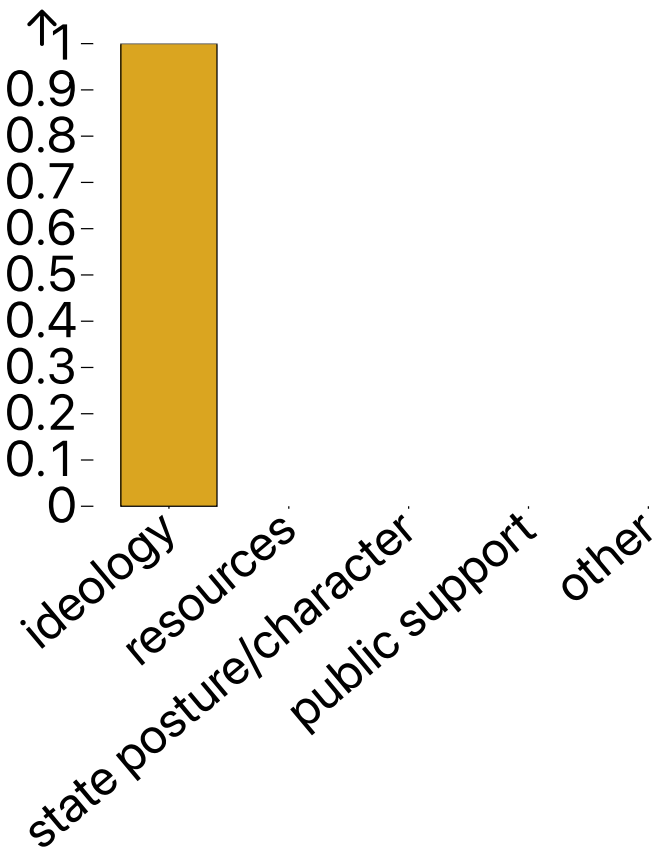
- most important factor shaping strategy?
- maximalist goals require extreme strategies?
- is popular support necessary for strategic success?
- political engagement necessary for big impact?
- disruptive tactics an effective way of generating awareness?

Questions about movements: (1) movement's organisational form? (2) movement relies on formal coordination structures (meetings, committees, roles)? (3) leadership plays a visible and strategic role in guiding the movement? (4) movement's main strategic orientation? (5) movement mainly uses conventional, legally permitted forms of protest? (6) movement's primary tactic of mobilisation?

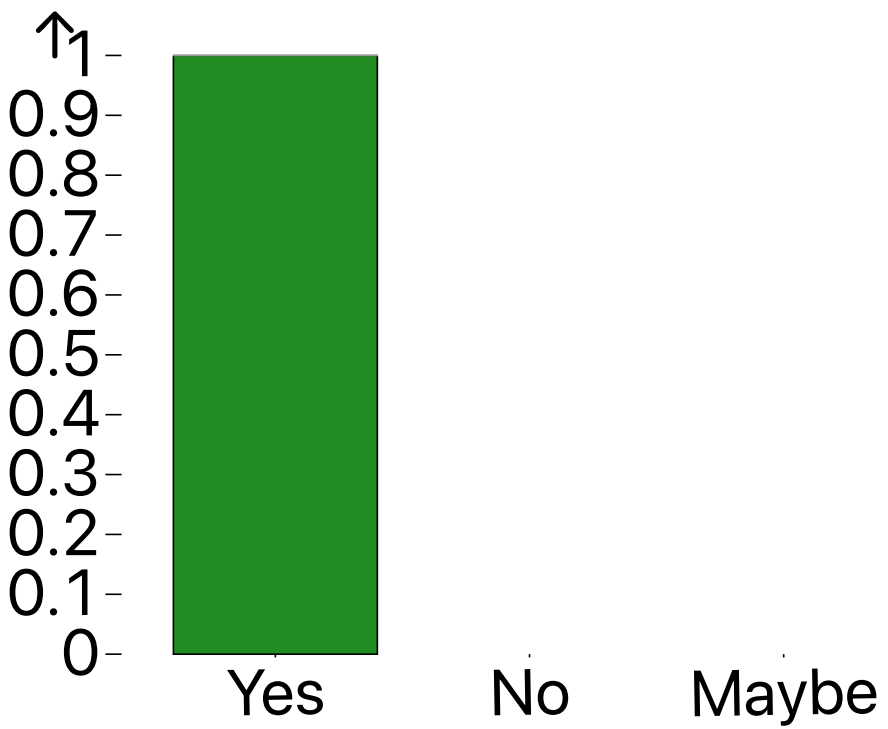
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Poll results (Respondents: 1)

most important factor shaping movement org. strategy?



do maximalist goals require more extreme strategies?




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Poll results

Tactical frivolity (Bogad 2016)

more of a humanities/dramaturgical perspective on movements and their tactics

Temporality

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- Grzymala-Busse (2011) on temporality
  - overview
  - definitions and examples
  - tempo and duration



Grzymala-Busse (2011) - overview

- mechanisms: “recurrent causal links between specified initial conditions and outcomes. Specific sequences (orderings) of mechanisms and events then constitute processes.”
- Fundamentals of temporality: how long events take (**duration**), how quickly they change (**tempo**), whether they speed up or slow down (**acceleration**), and when they occur (**timing**)

Grzymala-Busse (2011) - definitions and examples

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Aspect	Definition	Examples
Duration	Temporal length of an event; how much time elapses between the start and end of an action or event	Time elapsed between the announcement that a new agency is founded and its demise, or the period between the takeoff of popular literacy and its full attainment
Tempo	Amount of change per unit of time (dist./time interval); frequency of the 'subevents' in a larger event, or between events in a process.	How much time elapses before each new state institution is established, between each new person gaining literacy
Acceleration (and deceleration)	Derivative of velocity with respect to time (direction vector/direction tempo); rate of change	Postcommunist privatization started to unfold very quickly, with a great deal of entrepreneurial activity and privatization auctions at the outset. In several countries, it then slowed down
Timing	Position on a temporal timeline (itself composed of some units of time, such as electoral cycles or years)	18th-century revolutions had pamphlets and word of mouth as their mobilizing techniques; 20th-century revolutions had television, radio, email, and cell phones at their disposal

Grzymala-Busse (2011) - tempo and duration

	Faster	Slower
Shorter	Radical processes: coups, revolutions, shock therapy, regime replacement, and some institutional creation (free elections)	Abruptly ending processes: threshold effects, bargaining, establishing some institutions (cf. postcommunist clientelism)
Longer	Lengthy instability: revolutions and wars, cascades, predation, postcommunist civil society growth, political party fission	Gradual processes: demographic change, spread of literacy and nationalism, linguistic transformations, quasiparameter change

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Tactics and effecting change

- connecting tactics to outcomes
- tactical innovation
- Spaßguerrillas
- Gene Sharp and nonviolence
- some fun examples



Connecting tactics to outcomes

- Gamson (1990) found that violent social movements (incl. 'strikes and disruptive techniques') are more likely than nonviolent to achieve their goal
  - more effective in attracting attention and imposing costs on targets/opponents
  - similarly found by Cress and Snow (2000)
  - BUT… opposite found on regime-challenging movements by Chenoweth and Stephan (2011)
  - Opposite also found in U.S. campus policy by Rojas (2006)

Connecting tactics to outcomes

- social control hypothesis (e.g., Piven and Cloward 1979)
  - disruptive protests/tactics allow movements to win concessions in exchange for ending protests/tactics (*coercion* mechanism)
- mass mobilisation/social pressure hypothesis (e.g., Chenoweth and Stephan 2011)
  - gaining enough (visible) support to pressure decision-makers into concessions (*consensus/demonstrative/persuasion* mechanisms)
    - implicit appeal to democratic norms

(necessity of) tactical innovation

- McAdam (1983): tactical interaction
  - movements *disrupt* as they mount a challenge
  - authorities/targets *adapt* to tactics, dulling their impact
  - movements *innovate* tactics to maintain effective strategy
- With responsive authorities/targets, **this cycle places high demands on movements**
  - (McAdam (1983) writes that by the end of the 1960s, U.S. black rights movement(s) had been made '*tactically impotent*')

Spaßguerrillas

- problem in student movement of unexciting and/or intimidating modes of activism
- Wolfgang Lefèvre (SDS leader):

> ‘Every event or demonstration should be inventively planned so that it is exciting and fun for students.’

- the ‘fun-fighters’ emerged from the *Sozialistischen Deutschen Studentenbund*
  - Fritz Teufel, Rainer Langhans advocate **playful tactics**
  - long legacy in German activism (e.g., ‘Front Deutscher Äpfel’)

Gene Sharp and nonviolence (Sharp 1973)

- '*political ju-jitsu*' (using opponents' strength against them): violent repression of nonviolent resistance strengthens resistance by creating sympathy for resisters

↓

Tactics in practice, example

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Tactics in practice, example

- 2016: U.S. state of Texas passes law allowing carrying handguns on university campuses
- at the same time, state ‘obsenity laws’ forbid bringing dildoes onto campus
- the ‘cocks not glocks’ campaign was born…



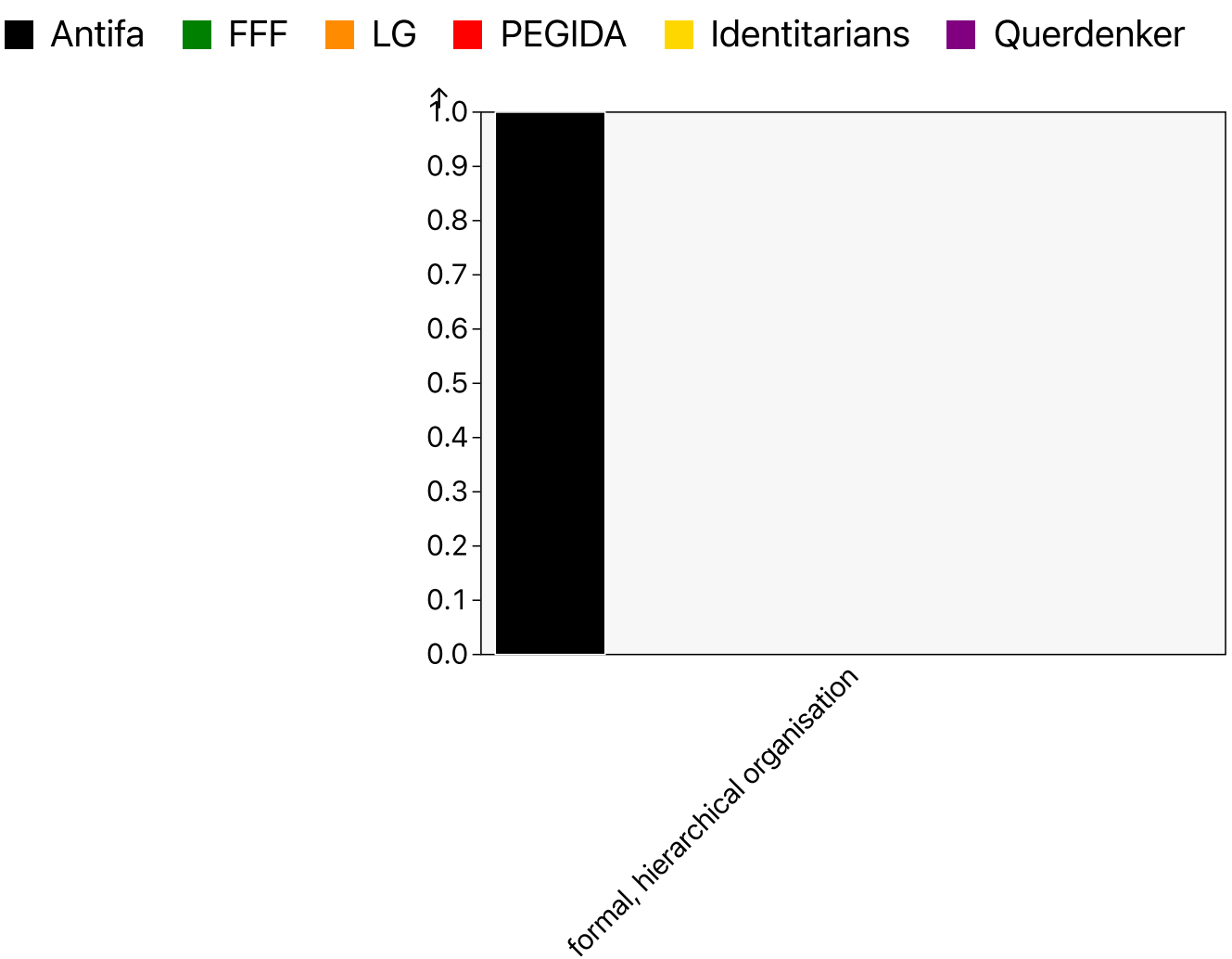
Student protesters with banners and dildos at the ‘Cocks Not Glocks’ protest (Picture: Rex)

Tactics in practice, example

‘We’re fighting absurdity with absurdity.’

Movement responses - org. form

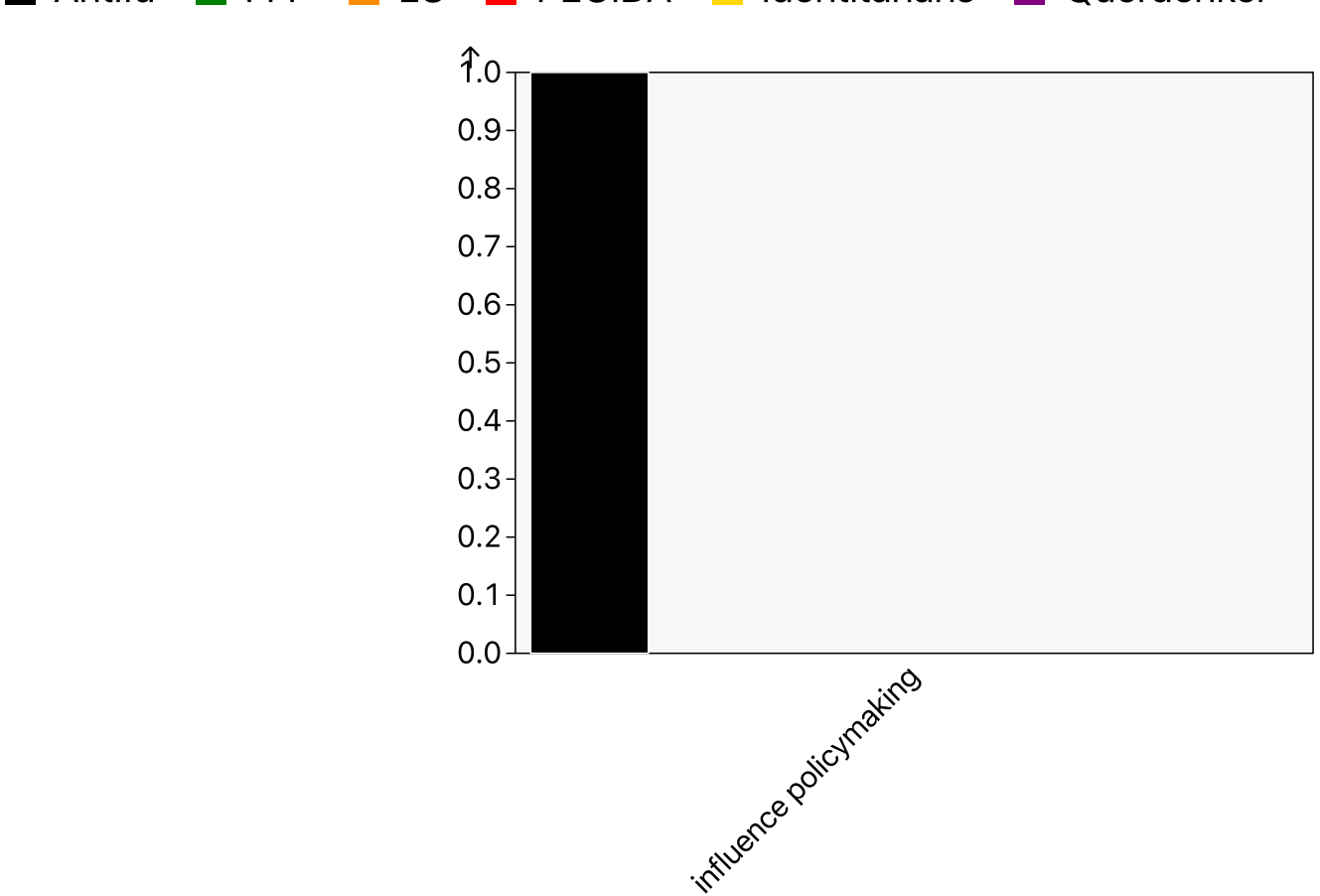
movement's organisational form?



Movement responses - structure and leaders

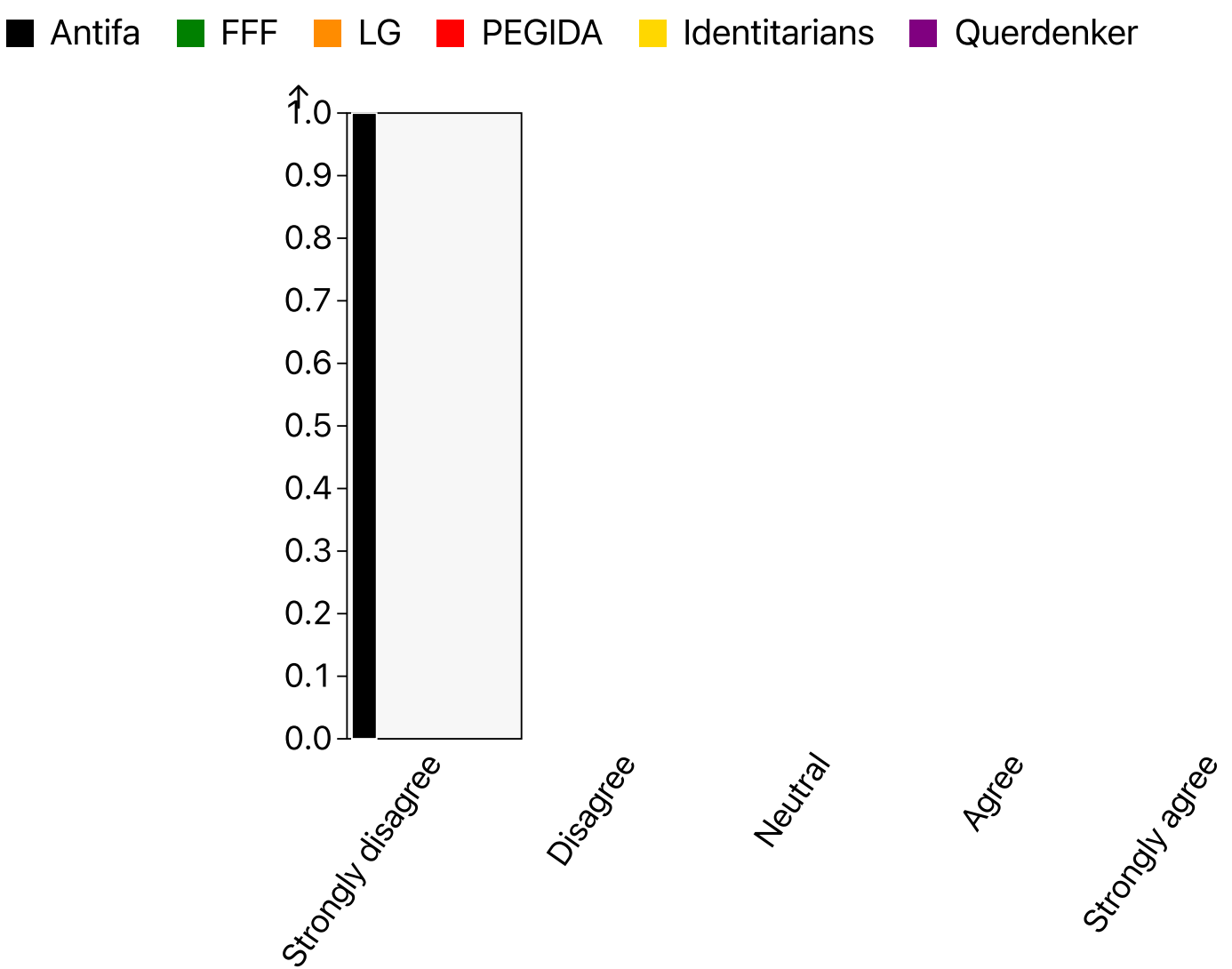
Movement responses - strategy

movement's main strategic orientation?



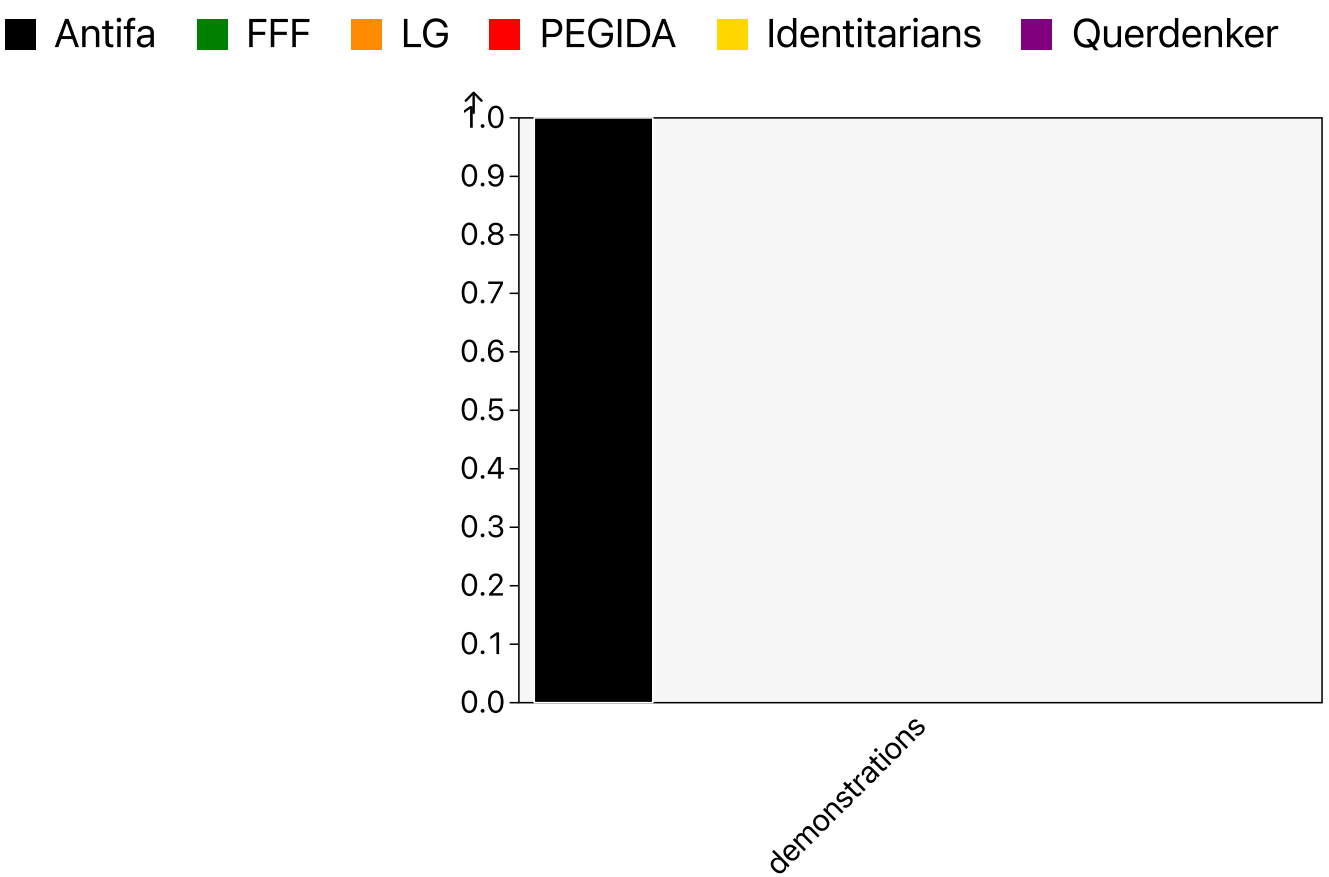
Movement responses - legal protest

movement mainly uses legally permitted protest?



Movement responses - tactics

movement's primary tactic of mobilisation?



Any questions, concerns, feedback on this class?

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Anonymous feedback here: https://forms.gle/AjHt6fcnwZxkSg4X8

Alternatively, please send me an email: m.zeller@lmu.de

Questions about movements next meeting: (1) Which type of media is most important for the movement's visibility? (2) Does the movement strategically plan actions to generate media coverage? (3) Is media coverage of the movement generally favourable? (4) Which audience is the movement mainly trying to influence? (5) Does the movement often succeed in getting its narratives spread through the media? (6) How successful has the movement been at influencing public debate?

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